PSYCHOLOGICAL/COGNITIVE FALSE BELIEF #33 · DEPRESSION

“There’s no use trying. I’ll only fail again.”

✦ ✦ ✦

Where it often comes from

Failure leaves a mark. A test, a job, a relationship, a habit, or a spiritual effort that collapsed can teach the next try to feel pointless before it starts. Depression adds a heavy voice: “You already know how this ends.” Quitting then feels like wisdom. It is often the lie protecting you from another disappointment, and it also keeps you from the very step that could go differently. If you are thinking about ending your life, call or text 988 in the United States, or tell someone near you right away.

What Scripture teaches

Scripture does not say that God’s people never fall. It says they do not have to stay down. “Let us not grow weary in well-doing, for in due time we will reap a harvest if we do not give up.” A righteous person may fall seven times and still get up. God, who began a good work, carries it on. These verses do not promise that the next try will be easy or that effort earns God’s love. They do say that one failure is not an order to stop.

> *“Let us not grow weary in well-doing, for in due time we will reap a harvest if we do not give up”* (Galatians 6:9).

Also see

> “For though a righteous man may fall seven times, he still gets up; but the wicked stumble in bad times” (Proverbs 24:16).

> “Do not fear, for I am with you; do not be afraid, for I am your God. I will strengthen you; I will surely help you; I will uphold you with My right hand of righteousness” (Isaiah 41:10).

> “Being confident of this, that He who began a good work in you will carry it on to completion until the day of Christ Jesus” (Philippians 1:6).

> “He heals the brokenhearted and binds up their wounds” (Psalm 147:3).

Common self-statements

- I already know I will fail.
- Trying just sets me up.
- People like me do not get back up.
- Effort is a waste.
- If I do not try, at least I cannot fail.
- I should quit before I am embarrassed again.

Common logical errors

- Fortune telling: Predicting the next try from the last failure.
- Overgeneralization: Turning some failures into “I always fail.”
- All-or-nothing thinking: Treating anything short of success as proof that trying is useless.
- Emotional reasoning: Feeling defeated and concluding that effort cannot matter.

Challenging questions

- What, exactly, am I afraid will happen if I try once more?
- Have I ever tried again and had a different result, even a small one?
- Is "I will only fail" a fact, or a way to avoid disappointment?
- What would a smaller, safer try look like?
- What does God say about falling and getting up?
- Who could take one step with me?

Truth summary

> One failure is not a reason to stop. I can take the next small step, and God gives strength to get up again.

Related Pearls topics

Click a topic to open it in the Pearls Scripture Search:

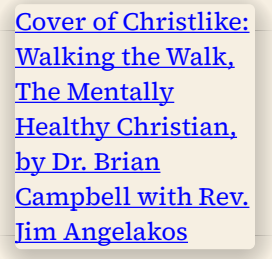
- Depression, Symptoms of
- Thinking, Healthy
- Help
- Hopeless
- Faith

Godly Counsel Lessons:

From the book *Godly Counsel* by Dr. Brian Campbell. Click a lesson to open it. You can read it on screen or print it.

- Depression
- Weak/Tired
- Thinking, Healthy

What does a mentally healthy Christian look like?



From *Christlike: Walking the Walk* by Dr. Brian Campbell. A portrait, verse by verse, of how a mentally healthy Christian thinks, feels, and lives.

Read excerpts from "The Mentally Healthy Christian" (with every Scripture written out)

Listen: Overcoming Depression

Overcoming Depression · Dr. Brian Campbell · about 20 minutes

Listen: Overcoming Anxiety

Overcoming Anxiety · Dr. Brian Campbell · about 18 minutes

Songs that speak truth to this belief

Voice of Truth — Casting Crowns
The voice that says you will only fail is not the voice of truth.

Greater — MercyMe
God's strength is greater than the failure in front of you.

Battle Belongs — Phil Wickham
You can bring the next step to God instead of carrying the outcome alone.

Victory in Jesus — Joy Gardner, Cynthia Clawson, Mike Allen and Reggie Smith
Getting up again belongs in the story. It is not proof you should quit.

Each morning ask: "If I truly believed God's truth instead of this lie, what is one step I could take today?"

HOMEWORK · REPLACE AND REHEARSE

My Plan for Replacing "There's no use trying. I'll only fail again."

✦ ✦ ✦

Read through each section and check the one that fits you best. If none of them fit, write your own. One choice per section is enough. A truth you choose for yourself will stick better than one handed to you.

Name: _____ Date started: _____

1 How strongly do I believe the lie?

Rate it now so you can see your progress later.

"There's no use trying. I'll only fail again." I believe this _____ % (0 = not at all, 100 = completely)

2 My best question

The one question I will ask myself every time the lie shows up.

- ☐ What, exactly, am I afraid will happen if I try once more?
- ☐ Have I ever tried again and had a different result, even a small one?
- ☐ Is "I will only fail" a fact, or a way to avoid disappointment?
- ☐ What would a smaller, safer try look like?
- ☐ What does God say about falling and getting up?
- ☐ Who could take one step with me?

My own question: _____

3 My replacement truth

The statement I will say to myself instead of the lie.

- ☐ One failure is not a reason to stop. I can take the next small step, and God gives strength to get up again.
- ☐ I can take one small step without guaranteeing the outcome.
- ☐ Falling does not mean I cannot get up.
- ☐ God strengthens me; I do not have to supply all the strength.
- ☐ A past failure is information, not a verdict.
- ☐ Quitting is not the same thing as wisdom.

In my own words: _____

4 My Scripture

The verse that speaks most directly to me. This is the one I will memorize.

- ☐ Galatians 6:9
  "Let us not grow weary in well-doing, for in due time we will reap a harvest if we do not give up."
- ☐ Proverbs 24:16
  "For though a righteous man may fall seven times, he still gets up; but the wicked stumble in bad times."
- ☐ Isaiah 41:10
  "Do not fear, for I am with you; do not be afraid, for I am your God. I will strengthen you; I will surely help you; I will uphold you with My right hand of righteousness."

A verse I found myself: _____

Practicing the Truth

✦ ✦ ✦

5 My practice plan

Everyone does the first four. Then pick one or two extra tools.

EVERYONE DOES THESE

- [ ] Make my Truth Card (below). Carry it and read it at least three times a day.
- [ ] Memorize my Scripture from Step 4.
- [ ] Listen to one song each day from "Songs that speak truth to this belief" on my card, and fill in my song journal (below).
- [ ] Set reminders to silently repeat my truth. Check one or more:
  - ☐ A buzz: my watch or phone vibrates every _____ minutes
  - ☐ An everyday event: every time I _____
  - ☐ A visual reminder: something I will see often, such as a sticky note on my mirror, my truth as the background picture on my phone, or a note on my car dashboard.

PICK ONE OR TWO THAT FIT ME

- [ ] When the "why try" feeling came: Each day, write down one moment when trying felt pointless. Write what happened, what you told yourself, and one more accurate statement.
- [ ] My name in Scripture: Write a personal reminder based on my verse and read it aloud. Keep this application separate from the Bible quotation.

  For example, Galatians 6:9 becomes: "Sarah can write: "I do not have to grow weary and quit. God can bring a harvest if I do not give up.""
- [ ] Gratitude journal: Each night, write three things I thank God for.
- [ ] Truth recording: Record my own voice reading my Truth Card and verse, and listen in the car or on a walk.
- [ ] Reading: The "Thinking, Healthy" topic in Pearls.
- [ ] Listening: The Overcoming Depression audio or the Overcoming Anxiety audio by Dr. Brian Campbell. Tap to play.

6 My action step this week

Do one thing that tests the lie in real life.

Choose steps you can do safely. If you are thinking about ending your life, call or text 988 (the Suicide & Crisis Lifeline), or call 911 in an emergency. You do not have to carry this alone.

- [ ] Shrink the try. Pick one step so small it can be finished today. Do it, and write what happened, not what you feared.
- [ ] Separate one failure from "always." List three things you have done that were not failures. Read the list when the lie speaks.
- [ ] Borrow a little courage. Tell one safe person the step you are avoiding, and ask them to check on you after you take it.
- [ ] Get help if giving up includes wanting to die. If you are thinking about ending your life, call or text 988, or tell someone near you today.

What I will do: _____

When: _____

What the lie predicts will happen: _____

7 End-of-week check-in

Bring this page to your next session.

What actually happened: _____

_____

What I learned: _____

The lie "There's no use trying. I'll only fail again.": _____ % My truth: _____ %

Daily practice tracker

Day	Read my card	Said my verse	Used my reminder	A step I took anyway
Mon				
Tue				
Wed				
Thu				
Fri				
Sat				
Sun				

My song journal

After each day's song, write what it told you that challenges the lie.

Day	Song I listened to	What it told me that challenges the lie
Mon		
Tue		
Wed		
Thu		
Fri		
Sat		
Sun		

My Truth Card

THE LIE

~~There's no use trying. I'll only fail again~~

THE TRUTH

GOD'S WORD

Copy onto a 3×5 card, or cut along the dashed line and carry it with you.

Prayer

Lord, I am tired of failing, and I am tempted to stop. Give me strength for one honest step, and remind me that falling is not the end of Your work in me. Amen.

Scripture quotations are from the Berean Standard Bible (BSB), which is in the public domain.